

Channels and Narratives: How State-Linked Actors, Proxies, and Hacktivists Shape Public Opinion Through Hybrid Cyber-Influence Operations

Prepared for the ITWeb Security Summit 2026 Keynote — Research Note 3 of 6

Question 5 of 6: How are state-linked actors, proxies and hacktivist groups using breach claims, leak sites, symbolic defacements and social media narratives to shape public opinion?

Executive Summary

Across all three geographic scopes — global, Africa, and South Africa — a consistent architecture emerges: perpetrators use cyber operations (whether an intrusion actually occurred or not) primarily as *credibility events* that unlock influence channels they could not otherwise access. The distinction between strictly-defined cyber-enabled influence (with a real intrusion) and loosely-defined cyber-enabled influence (no intrusion, but cyber infrastructure as the distribution mechanism) matters enormously for attribution and legal response, but less so for the audience receiving the influence content. Five channel categories dominate: (1) dark-web and criminal leak sites, (2) state-owned and proxy media ecosystems, (3) Telegram and encrypted-messaging channels, (4) hijacked or spoofed legitimate media infrastructure, and (5) social media amplification networks. The narratives carried through these channels are not random — they cluster around a small number of recurring frames: vulnerability and impunity ("no-one can protect you"), political delegitimisation ("elections are rigged"), anti-Western neocolonialism (dominant in Africa), and extortion coercion ("pay or your data goes public"). The 4th EEAS Annual Report on FIMI Threats (March 2026) identifies increased hybridisation, AI-enabled content generation, and increased covertness as the three defining trends of 2025 FIMI activity, with AI tool use in detected FIMI incidents rising approximately 259% compared to 2024. This report maps these channels and narratives across geographic scopes with specific grounding in the hybrid incidents PDF dataset.^[^1]

Part I — Global Level

1. From the Hybrid Incidents PDF

The PDF dataset documents a rich variety of channel and narrative strategies across its 101 incidents (fit ≥ 0.7). The key channel-narrative pairings it reveals are as follows:

Hack-and-leak → WikiLeaks / front-persona sites / social media amplification (Type 1b)

The DNC (NA-6), DCCC (NA-5), Podesta (NA-9), and Macron Leaks (EU-22) operations share an almost identical playbook: stolen material is laundered through one or more cutout

personas or third-party platforms (Guccifer 2.0, DCLeaks, WikiLeaks, Pastebin, 4chan), with social media amplification — primarily on X/Twitter — converting the raw dump into a news event. The Macron Leaks operation added a distinctive layer: forged documents were mixed with authentic stolen files before release, exploiting both the authenticity of the genuine material and the confusion generated by the fakes. The IRGC's 2024 US election hack-and-leak (NA-7) updated this model by targeting individual journalists directly with unsolicited stolen material, bypassing public dump sites entirely — a technique that reduces risk of immediate attribution while exploiting journalists' professional instinct to investigate politically relevant material.

Fake media infrastructure → redirect chains → social media seeding (Type 1c, no intrusion)

Doppelganger, the dominant Russian influence franchise in the dataset, does not require unauthorised access to any victim system. Its architecture is entirely synthetic: cybersquatted or typosquat domains (e.g., `washingtonpost.pm`) serve as credibility anchors; AI-generated articles carry pro-Kremlin narratives; paid social media advertisements and fake-persona networks drive traffic; and bot amplification extends reach. The Justice Department's seizure of 32 Doppelganger domains in September 2024 exposed an internal strategy specifically targeting American demographic segments through tailored content. At the EU level, the 3rd EEAS FIMI Report identified 38,000 channels involved in FIMI activity in 2024, with Doppelganger as the central franchise, supported by the Pravda network, Ghostwriter, and Operation Overload as supplementary operations.

DDoS + Telegram claim channel (Type 1g / Type 3)

NoName05716 exemplifies a distinct hybrid architecture: the DDoS attack is itself the message, and the Telegram channel (~20,000 members) is the megaphone. Each attack wave is announced in advance, contextualised as punishment for a specific Western government decision (German Leopard tank deliveries, Czech presidential election, G7 reaffirmations of Ukraine support), and then verified via CheckHost screenshots posted back to the channel. This creates a closed narrative loop: the attack produces a screenshot, the screenshot produces a news story, the news story produces political pressure. The Ukrainian IT Army (EU-39) uses an almost identical model in the opposite direction: DDoS and defacement actions against Russian and Belarusian sites are publicised through Telegram and online coordination channels, creating wartime participation narratives and recruiting further volunteers.

Dark-web leak sites → mainstream press pickup (Type 2f, criminal)

The criminal ransomware operations in the dataset — ALPHV/Change Healthcare (NA-16), REvil/JBS (NA-15), RansomEXX/Kenya Airways (AF-9), and the entire South Africa cluster — operate on the principle that the dark-web leak site converts a private extortion demand into a public reputational crisis. The narrative is deliberately calibrated: rather than making political claims, criminal groups present themselves as exposing the victim's negligence. ALPHV's extraordinary exit-scam against its own affiliate in the Change Healthcare case introduced a third-order narrative complication, with fake law-enforcement-seizure notices on the group's own leak site designed to deceive both its affiliate community and the press.

Compromised broadcaster channels and signage (Type 1c / 1d, intrusion-dependent)

The TV5Monde attack (EU-37) and the Taiwan digital signage campaign during Nancy Pelosi's

visit (AS-7) represent the highest-visibility sub-type of intrusion-dependent influence: hijacking trusted public-facing infrastructure to broadcast hostile content. The TV5Monde case combined genuine propaganda (jihadist iconography, IS content, threats against French soldiers) with false-flag attribution (the CyberCaliphate persona), exploiting the broadcaster's established credibility with French-speaking global audiences. The Taiwan signage hack achieved maximum psychological effect through symbolic humiliation — convenience store screens and train station displays in a democratic, self-governing society suddenly displaying PRC unification messaging during the most geopolitically sensitive visit to the island in 25 years.

Surveillance + smear narratives (Type 1a, intrusion-dependent)

The BadBazaar mobile surveillance campaign (AS-1) and Iran's cyber repression of ethnic minorities (AS-4) use intrusion — trojanised applications, account compromise — to generate intelligence that fuels smear and intimidation campaigns against diaspora activists. Iran's MOIS-linked actors used Telegram groups, fake content planted on social media, and mass reporting to suppress dissident accounts — a micro-targeted influence architecture invisible to the audiences it was not designed to affect.

Operation Overload: exploiting the fact-checking infrastructure itself

One of the most analytically interesting channels documented in sources referenced by the PDF is Operation Overload — a campaign that inverts the normal influence model by using the fact-checking apparatus as an amplifier. Pro-Russian actors flood more than 800 media organisations with anonymous emails containing links to fabricated content, framed as citizen tip-offs asking journalists to investigate "Kremlin propaganda." When journalists publish debunks, the narrative reaches wider audiences than the original fake ever would have. This no-intrusion model exploits professional journalistic norms rather than technical vulnerabilities.

2. Beyond the PDF: The Global Channel Ecosystem

Strictly Intrusion-Dependent Channels

WikiLeaks-era hack-and-dump platforms have been largely superseded, but their functional successors — DDoSecrets (Distributed Denial of Secrets), dedicated dark-web forums, and direct journalist outreach — continue to fulfil the same role. The key evolution since 2016 is that state actors have become more selective in release strategy: rather than bulk-dumping to the public, the IRGC's 2024 operation specifically targeted individual journalists with non-public Trump campaign material, seeking to trigger *reporting* rather than direct public consumption.

False-flag ransomware as influence operation: MuddyWater (Iranian MOIS) has been running a sustained false-flag campaign (Operation MuddyWater, ongoing into 2026) in which state-sponsored espionage intrusions are dressed as criminal ransomware activity, using Chaos RaaS branding and extortion messaging to confuse incident response and mask the underlying intelligence collection. The influence effect here is dual: victims misattribute the

operation to criminals, suppressing political response; and genuine criminal groups benefit from reputational noise that inhibits law enforcement prioritisation.

Loosely-Defined Cyber-Enabled Influence (No Intrusion)

The EEAS 4th Annual Report (March 2026) documents 540 FIMI incidents in 2025, with 10,500 social media channels and websites mobilised to produce or amplify content. The dominant no-intrusion model is the **multilayer fake-media ecosystem**: fabricated outlets at the top of the funnel (Doppelganger, Spamouflage, Ghostwriter spoofed sites), amplification by inauthentic social media personas in the middle, and organic reach through algorithm-gaming at the bottom. Russia (29%) and China (6%) account for 35% of attributed incidents, but the report explicitly notes that both states rely on covert networks to expand reach while preserving deniability.

AI as a channel multiplier: Generative AI has shifted from experimental to routine deployment in FIMI operations. Key use cases documented in 2025: synthetic audio for fake phone calls and fabricated statements by political figures; AI-generated video for deepfake politician statements; AI text for scaling up fake news articles across multiple languages; and automated translation for reaching non-English-speaking audiences. The Iranian Storm-2035 group deployed four AI-powered fake news websites targeting both liberal and conservative US audiences ahead of the 2024 election, with content tailored to demographic segments.

Narrative taxonomy across intrusion and non-intrusion types:

Narrative Frame	Typical Channel	Intrusion Required?	Primary Actor Type
"Elections are stolen / illegitimate"	Fake news sites, social media CIB	No	State (Russia, China, Iran)
"Western support for Ukraine will destroy your economy"	Doppelganger, Telegram, RT/Sputnik	No	State (Russia)
"Your data is ours — pay or it goes public"	Dark-web leak sites, Telegram DM, press leaks	Yes (data theft)	Criminal (RaaS)
"Your institution is weak and indefensible"	Leak site countdown timers, sample data dumps	Yes (data theft)	Criminal (RaaS)
"This attack is retaliation for [specific policy]"	Telegram claim channels, hacktivist statements	Yes (DDoS/defacement)	Hacktivist proxy (NoName, IT Army)
"We are exposing state wrongdoing / censorship"	Hack-and-dump sites, WikiLeaks successors	Yes (data theft)	State (GRU APT28) with proxy laundering
"[Minority group] are security threats / criminals"	State media, fake social accounts, Telegram smear	Yes (surveillance-derived)	State (China/Iran)
"[Broadcaster/platform] has been compromised"	Hijacked media channels, spoof social accounts	Yes (account/system compromise)	State (GRU, PLA-SSF)

Narrative Frame	Typical Channel	Intrusion Required?	Primary Actor Type
"Our adversary is losing / weak / disorganised"	Telegram, press releases, CheckHost screenshots	Yes (DDoS)	Hacktivist (both sides)
"France/West is a neocolonial exploiter"	Facebook, TikTok, local media proxies	No	State proxy (Wagner/African Initiative)

Part II — Africa Level

1. From the Hybrid Incidents PDF

The Africa chapter of the PDF (20 incidents, 9 qualifying at $\text{fit} \geq 0.7$) reveals a sharp channel bifurcation:

The qualifying incident channel landscape is almost entirely criminal and extortion-focused. All nine qualifying incidents are ransomware double-extortion operations, and the channel architecture is consistent across them:

- **The dark-web leak site as the primary pressure channel:** RansomEXX used its dark-web site to post Kenya Airways passport copies, police investigation reports, and staff records — selectively showcasing the most embarrassing and sensitive material to maximise reputational fear. The Transnet case used a ransom note on victim systems plus a dark-web negotiation portal, and the force-majeure declaration at Durban port converted what might have been a private extortion into national and international press coverage. Cell C (RansomHouse) had its stolen customer data published publicly on RansomHouse's leak site, where it was linked directly from evidence packs — no password required.
- **Telegram as the negotiation and coercion channel:** N4ughtySecTU communicated with TransUnion South Africa via Telegram, and later approached TransUnion's corporate clients — Absa, FNB, Standard Bank, Nedbank, Discovery — with individually targeted insurance-fee demands, using Telegram and Session for direct contact. This hybrid of criminal data-theft and targeted individual outreach represents an Africa-specific evolution of the extortion model, exploiting the absence of robust breach-notification law and the reputational vulnerability of South Africa's major banks.
- **Mainstream press as an involuntary amplifier:** ITWeb, MyBroadband, TimesLive, [DataBreaches.net](#), and the Daily Maverick were all cited in the PDF as secondary channels through which the criminal actors' narratives reached wider audiences — not through hacking, but through normal press coverage of the breach. The narrative in each case was supplied by the attackers through their public-facing leak sites and Telegram statements, and then reproduced (with appropriate scepticism) by journalists.

The 11 Africa incidents that did not qualify ($\text{fit} < 0.7$) are dominated by Russian-linked and domestic-political CIB operations targeting Sahel francophone countries and central African Republic — precisely the category of influence operation most relevant to the "channels and

narratives" question but excluded from the qualifying dataset because they lack a confirmed intrusion. This is the most significant structural gap in the PDF for the Africa level.

2. Beyond the PDF: Russia's African Channel Architecture

Russia's African influence infrastructure, significantly expanded following the Prigozhin-era Wagner operations, operates through a multi-layer channel ecosystem that requires no intrusion:

The overt broadcast layer: RT Africa (available in Maghreb, Côte d'Ivoire, Senegal, Burkina Faso, and Cameroon) and Sputnik Afrique (French-language, launched July 2022 after French court-ordered liquidation, operating from Algeria) serve as the credibility anchors. In August 2024, RT ran a physical billboard campaign in multiple African cities featuring anti-colonial imagery — Julius Nyerere, Kwame Nkrumah, Robert Mugabe — with the tagline "Your Values. Shared," explicitly positioning RT as the media voice of African self-determination. Sputnik operates dedicated Telegram channels in English, French, and Amharic.

The proxy media layer: Afrique Média (Cameroon-based TV channel) functions as a legitimising proxy, carrying Kremlin narratives under local branding. The Kenya-based Code for Africa found that Afrique Média "follows Putin's philosophy of promoting Russia's agenda in Africa" while avoiding the RT/Sputnik brand taint in markets where those outlets are associated with propaganda. The 2025 Lansing Institute report identifies the African Initiative Agency — the post-Prigozhin successor to Wagner's civilian influence arm — as coordinating with Rossotrudnichestvo (Russia's soft-power agency), local NGOs, journalism schools in Mali, and paid influencers to run ideological and psychological operations.

The social media and micro-targeting layer: The Africa Center for Strategic Studies (March 2024) identified Russia as the primary agent of 80 of nearly 200 documented disinformation campaigns across Africa, representing a fourfold increase over two years. Facebook and TikTok are the primary platforms. A documented operation in Côte d'Ivoire in 2023 used at least 64 pro-Russian coordinated accounts, paid Facebook advertisements targeted to Abidjan demographics (predominantly male audiences), and cartoon videos depicting Russian mercenaries defeating French forces. The ECFR (November 2025) documented fake Burkina Faso "development miracle" videos on TikTok and YouTube — none of the claimed achievements (first African electric vehicle, IMF debt elimination, industrial renaissance) real — achieving millions of views.

The core narrative frames for Africa:

- *France as neocolonial predator:* exploiting deep historical grievances about Françafrique, CFA franc monetary control, and French military presence
- *Russia as anti-colonial liberator:* positioning Wagner/Russian troops as the legitimate security partners that Western forces never were
- *African sovereignty and dignity:* framing opposition to Western democratic conditionality as genuine African self-determination

- *Discrediting electoral oversight*: targeting election observers, civil-society organisations, and Western-funded democracy support programmes as foreign interference in African sovereignty

The Sahel as laboratory: Forbidden Stories' November 2024 investigation documented an operation in Mali where Russian-linked actors arranged trips to Russia for Malian journalists, who returned and organised pro-Russian events; sponsored a journalism school through African Initiative; and operated anonymous Wagner-linked social media accounts that local pro-junta activist groups then amplified for local credibility. Disinformation in this environment is described as pervasive across "state and private media outlets" — a whole-of-information-environment operation rather than a targeted campaign.

Team Jorge and commercial election interference: The 2023 Haaretz/Guardian investigation into Team Jorge — a commercial influence-as-a-service operation based in Israel — documented an advanced Telegram bot army infrastructure (AIMS: Advanced Impact Media Solutions) capable of managing tens of thousands of fake personas simultaneously, with documented use in African elections (Kenya 2022 among them). This represents the commercial, non-state end of the influence market: the same channels and techniques as state operations, but available to any political client who can pay.

Part III — South Africa Level

1. From the Hybrid Incidents PDF

South Africa accounts for nine of the PDF's twenty Africa incidents — all criminal ransomware double-extortion — and the channel architecture across them is consistent:

Leak sites as coercive public shaming: The Transnet attack (AF-14) produced a ransom note claiming 1TB of exfiltration, a dark-web negotiation portal, and extensive national and international press coverage triggered by the force-majeure declaration. The political timing — the attack came days after the July 2021 KwaZulu-Natal unrest — generated public speculation of coordinated economic destabilisation, even though authorities concluded the two events were unrelated; the coincidence itself was a narrative gift to anyone wishing to frame the attack as politically motivated.

Telegram as targeted extortion channel: N4ughtySecTU's innovation in the TransUnion case was to combine a public leak-site threat with individualised Telegram outreach to TransUnion's corporate clients, demanding smaller "insurance fees" (R1 million for large clients, R100,000 for smaller ones) to be excluded from any future data release. This two-tier model — public reputational pressure through the leak site, private financial pressure through Telegram — is a sophisticated South Africa-specific adaptation.

Press coverage as amplification channel: Daily Maverick, ITWeb, and TimesLive provided extensive coverage of the TransUnion breach, including publication of the attackers' Telegram statements. The attackers' claim that the entry password was literally "Password" became a widely shared narrative — the breach story is remembered in South Africa not

primarily for the data loss but for the institutional negligence narrative the attackers supplied.

The Cell C (AF-17) case demonstrates RansomHouse's default channel architecture applied to South Africa: a short advisory posted to the dark-web leak site, a message to Cell C management ("Dear management of Cell C. We are sure that you are not interested in your confidential data to be leaked or sold to a third party. We highly advise you to contact us."), followed by full data dump publication after non-payment — downloadable without a password by any interested party.

What the PDF does not cover at South Africa level: The PDF's ≥ 0.7 threshold excludes all CIB/social-media influence operations that lack an intrusion component. As the Africa continental observations note explicitly, 11 of 20 Africa incidents were CIB operations primarily attributable to Russian-linked or domestic political-PR networks — but none of these reached the qualifying threshold. The South Africa political influence environment, which is substantial, is therefore entirely absent from the qualifying PDF data.

2. Beyond the PDF: South Africa's Information Environment

The Russian and Geopolitically-Motivated Influence Layer (No Intrusion)

South Africa's BRICS membership, non-alignment in the Ukraine conflict, and hosting of the 2025 BRICS summit make it a strategically important node in Russia's global narrative competition. The channel architecture targeting South Africa differs from the Sahel model: rather than establishing RT/Sputnik bureaux or proxy media outlets at scale, Russia's South Africa influence strategy exploits existing political receptivity and domestic media infrastructure.

RT's August 2024 billboard campaign ran in Johannesburg as part of the wider sub-Saharan Africa push. Sputnik Africa maintains active Telegram and X/Twitter accounts in English, though its South African-specific following is modest compared to its francophone African presence. The more significant channel is organic amplification by South African politicians, commentators, and media outlets who share Russian-aligned narratives — not because they are paid operatives but because those narratives align with genuine non-aligned political sentiment.

The "White Genocide" Narrative: A Case Study in Global-Domestic Hybrid Influence

The most geopolitically consequential narrative campaign involving South Africa in 2024–2026 is the "white genocide" / Afrikaner farmer persecution narrative, which has been amplified internationally by Donald Trump and Elon Musk and domestically contested by a range of actors. This narrative operates through multiple channel layers simultaneously:

- **Presidential and tech-billionaire platforms (no intrusion):** Trump's X/Twitter statements and official US State Department communications framing South Africa's land-reform debate as genocide reached global audiences of hundreds of millions. Musk's

amplification of related content, and the extraordinary incident of Grok (xAI's chatbot on X) spontaneously injecting "white genocide" references into unrelated conversations in May 2025, demonstrated how AI systems trained on algorithmically-amplified content can become autonomous narrative amplifiers.

- **South African domestic influencer networks (no intrusion):** ISS research published in March 2025 documented South African political influencers explicitly gaming X/Twitter algorithms through cross-border "rage bait" — artificially provoking nationalist reactions to boost engagement and build pan-African audience networks. Some of these influencers were financially motivated; others were ideologically driven. The IEC and other democratic institutions were primary targets of coordinated false narratives during the 2024 election.
- **WhatsApp as the closed-chain amplification channel:** A peer-reviewed study of 22,384 messages from 47 politically active South African WhatsApp groups during the 2024 election (Gondwe, 2025) found that political disinformation relied primarily on fear-based appeals (41%), identity-driven rhetoric (32%), and content mimicking credible journalism (27%). Critically, corrective content was routinely dismissed within these groups as "propaganda or foreign interference" — the closed-chain architecture creates epistemically sealed communities resistant to fact-checking.

The ICJ Genocide Case: A Contested-Legitimacy Narrative Channel

South Africa's case before the International Court of Justice alleging Israeli genocide in Gaza has generated a sustained narrative competition in which both Israeli-government-linked and South African government-aligned actors use social media and media infrastructure (without intrusion) to shape the framing of the proceedings. This is a textbook Type 1c operation (cyber-enabled influence via fake/inauthentic assets) in the loosely-defined sense — using social media bot networks and paid content to shape a complex legal process in public opinion. The specific channel and attribution details remain partially undocumented in open sources.

The South Africa Ransomware Narrative Problem: An Underappreciated Dimension

The criminal ransomware ecosystem targeting South Africa has an underappreciated secondary narrative effect: each major breach — Transnet, TransUnion, Experian, Cell C, MTN — reinforces a *structural vulnerability* narrative about South Africa's digital infrastructure that is geopolitically exploitable even without coordination. The cumulative message to international investors, trading partners, and South African citizens is that critical digital infrastructure cannot be protected. Whether or not this is the intent of financially motivated criminal groups, it functions as a strategic effect indistinguishable from a deliberate information operation targeting economic confidence.

Part IV — Cross-Cutting Analysis: The Strict/Loose Distinction in Channel Terms

The distinction between intrusion-dependent and no-intrusion influence channels matters in three analytically important ways:

1. Authenticity Premium of Intrusion-Based Operations

When a genuine breach has occurred, the attacker controls genuine material — real emails, real data, real internal communications — that cannot be dismissed as fabricated. The Macron Leaks, DNC, and Podesta operations derived their influence power precisely from the authenticity of the stolen content (even where it was mixed with forgeries). No-intrusion influence operations must manufacture credibility through volume, consistency, and platform amplification rather than evidential authenticity. This is why Doppelganger uses legitimate news outlet domain names — it is purchasing reflected credibility in place of the genuine credibility that stolen authentic material would provide.

2. Attribution Complexity and Plausible Deniability

No-intrusion influence operations are structurally easier to deny and harder to attribute. State actors operating through synthetic media ecosystems (Doppelganger, Spamouflage, African Initiative networks) can maintain "no government official did anything" plausible deniability that is simply unavailable when an intrusion has been forensically linked to state infrastructure. The 4th EEAS report notes that Russia and China deliberately outsource capability through "opaque covert and fabricated networks" specifically to exploit this attribution asymmetry.

3. Legal and Regulatory Landscape

The strict/loose distinction maps closely onto the legal response space. Intrusion-dependent operations engage cybercrime law, enabling prosecution (IRGC indictments, GRU attribution leading to EU sanctions, Europol Operation Eastwood against NoName05716). No-intrusion operations engage information law — the EU's Digital Services Act, Electoral Integrity provisions, and the emerging FIMI legal framework — a slower, less decisive, and jurisdiction-dependent response. South Africa has no equivalent to the EU FIMI framework for the domestic no-intrusion influence environment, creating a regulatory gap that all classes of actor exploit.

Part V — Synthesis Table: Channels and Narratives by Geographic Scope

Dimension	Global	Africa	South Africa
Dominant channel (intrusion-based)	WikiLeaks-successors, dark-web leak sites, hijacked broadcaster/signage	Dark-web leak sites + Telegram DM extortion	Leak sites + Telegram extortion targeting corporate clients

Dimension	Global	Africa	South Africa
Dominant channel (no intrusion)	Doppelganger fake sites, Telegram claim channels, AI-generated fake news outlets	Facebook/TikTok local proxy outlets, RT/Sputnik Africa, Telegram bot networks	WhatsApp closed chains, X/Twitter amplification, domestic influencer networks
Primary state-actor narrative	Anti-Ukraine / election delegitimisation (Russia); sovereignty / Taiwan (China); anti-US polarisation (Iran)	Anti-France neocolonialism; Russia as liberator; election observer delegitimisation	BRICS non-alignment validation; white genocide amplification (external); election manipulation (domestic)
Primary criminal narrative	"Your data is ours, pay or it goes public"	"A flagship national institution is unprotected"	"Critical SA infrastructure is indefensible"; individual consumer exposure
Primary hacktivist narrative	"We punish Ukraine's backers"; "We resist Russian aggression"	Rare in qualifying dataset; some anti-Western infrastructure disruption claims	Not documented at qualifying threshold
Key no-intrusion amplifier	Paid social media ads, AI-generated content, fake influencer networks	Local media proxies, Wagner-aligned journalists, bot networks	WhatsApp group dynamics, algorithm gaming on X, rage-bait cross-border engagement
Key intrusion-based credibility mechanism	Authentic stolen documents laundered through front personas	Selective sample publication on leak sites to prove exfiltration occurred	Two-tier extortion: leak site (public)+ Telegram (targeted institutional clients)
Gap / blind spot	Western government operations (US CYBERCOM Kontur Novosti) remain partially documented	Russian/domestic CIB operations excluded by PDF threshold; Team Jorge commercial layer	All non-criminal influence operations (ICJ, white genocide narrative, BRICS) below PDF threshold

Conclusions for the Keynote

Several findings from this analysis are directly actionable for the ITWeb Security Summit keynote audience — South African security practitioners and leaders:

1. **The channel is often more important than the content.** Doppelganger's power comes not from particularly convincing fake articles but from placing those articles at URLs that look identical to trusted media outlets. The credibility debt is borrowed, not earned. Defenders who focus only on content moderation miss the architectural vulnerability.
2. **Criminal ransomware operations are functioning as unintentional state-narrative infrastructure.** The cumulative effect of South Africa's extraordinarily high density of major ransomware victims — Transnet, TransUnion, Experian, Cell C, MTN, Sibanye-Stillwater, Astral Foods — is a structural vulnerability narrative that no disinformation campaign needs to fabricate. Security leaders should communicate resilience and recovery as explicitly as they communicate breach disclosure.

3. WhatsApp is the dominant no-intrusion influence channel in South Africa, and it is effectively ungovernable by external parties. The Gondwe (2025) study shows that corrective content is systematically rejected within ideologically cohesive WhatsApp groups. The implication for security leaders is that trusted-messenger pre-inoculation (before a crisis) matters more than reactive fact-checking (after a breach claim circulates).
4. The strict/loose distinction identifies who needs to respond. Intrusion-dependent operations require cybersecurity response, law enforcement, and incident communications. No-intrusion operations require media literacy, platform governance, and regulatory response. South Africa has relatively mature institutional capacity for the first and very limited capacity for the second.
5. The 4th EEAS FIMI Report's FIMI Deterrence Playbook — targeting the financial, technical, and organisational *enablers* of influence operations rather than individual pieces of content — offers a strategic framework relevant beyond the EU context. For South Africa, this means prioritising disruption of bulletproof hosting infrastructure, cryptocurrency payment rails for ransomware, and the commercial intermediaries who sell influence-as-a-service domestically.

References

1. [Sae Schatz's Post - LinkedIn](#) - READ ME: The 4th EEAS Report on FIMI just dropped. The European External Action Service (EEAS) relea...